

The Business of Cricket

# Winning Formula

The Twenty20 format delivers more bang for the buck for advertisers and enables broadcasters to sell ad spots easily. It also attracts a new, younger audience and new sponsors and advertisers.

**I**ndian *Idol* 3 winner Prashant Tamang can move over, because cricket's biggest reality TV show is here and it has captured the imagination of a billion Indians. T20 has hit the world of television like a tsunami, where Yuvraj Singh's longest sixer, at 119 m, is far more enthralling than an *Idol* contestant's copious tears. Shefali Chachi, brand head of Nokia, a key sponsor of the ICC T20 World Cup, calls this new format the "soccerisation of cricket". At a qualitative level, she feels, the viewership should be high as interest has risen dramatically.

Not surprisingly, the ICC World Twenty20 has dealt a severe blow to the ratings of some of the top-rated programmes on the TV channels. During the India-Pakistan match on September 14, reality programmes slotted during the same time band, like *Indian Idol* 3 on Sony and *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Challenge* on Zee TV, saw their ratings plummet. The *Indian Idol* 3 rating saw a drop of 35 per cent from the previous week's 3.8 and touched 2.5 on the day of the match. Similar was the case with *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa*, which saw the ratings drop from 6 to 4.2 during the finals. Television ratings created history during the India-Pakistan match on September 24, 2007, as TVRs touched a peak of 15.2. The combined channel shares for ESPN and Star Cricket stood at 47.2 per cent, way ahead of all other channels.

For naysayers who may call this new format a flash in the pan, the viewer interest in the non-India matches clearly indicates that the new format is a resounding hit. The interest factor in the non-India matches has

been unusually high, with the first match between hosts South Africa and West Indies recording a TVR of 5.8. The average ratings for all the matches during the group stage of ICC World Twenty20 between September 11-15 scored an impressive 3.95 TVR, which is close to if not higher than the rating of leading reality shows.

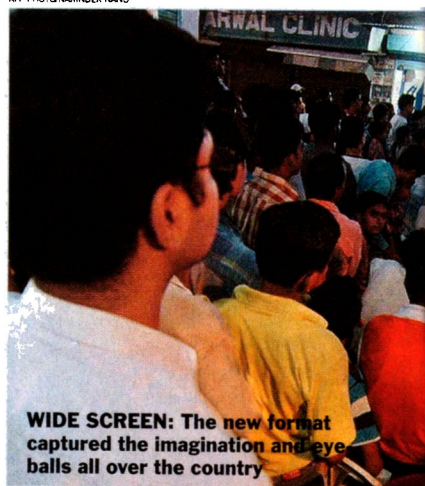
Says Manish Porwal, general manager of media buying agency Starcom Worldwide, "T20 is the renaissance of Indian cricket because it has changed the way the game is played and viewed. The three-hour game is now more like an action-packed film."

Clearly, the game has a much better connect with the under-20 population because it is quick and full of energy. With shorter attention span of the audience, doing away with 30 overs will deliver better efficiency to the advertisers and enable broadcasters to sell ad spots easily. The tight format of the game does not allow a viewer to go away even for a minute. In a regular ODI, there are 45,000-50,000 seconds of advertising spots available, but in a T20, only 1,500 seconds are available for ads. Says Porwal: "There is attention deficit today among the audience. The success of T20 and failure of long-running soaps is testimony of this. As a format, T20 is here to stay."

The key sponsors of the T20 World Cup—Yahoo, Reliance Communications, Pepsi, Nokia—are indicative of the game's changing stakeholders. The official sponsors of the past, namely Coke and Pepsi, no longer own cricket as they did a few years ago. Given that cricket has been a very expensive advertising vehicle, only large MNCs could

afford to associate with the game, but with the new format, a whole lot of new advertisers are jumping onto the bandwagon as the game has caught the frenzy of a whole new audience. Yahoo, a youth brand, chose the T20 to make its debut in cricket advertising. Says Aparna Pujar, head of content at Yahoo India: "The T20 audience will grow as the popularity of the event grows. With

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**WIDE SCREEN:** The new format captured the imagination and eyeballs all over the country

500 million daily users, Yahoo has brought fantastic synergy to the event as we wanted to connect with cricket fans all over the world." Yahoo is looking at extending its partnership with ICC for eight years and all four T20 World Cups, for which media planners claim it may have to cough up anything between \$60 (Rs 240 crore) and \$100 million (Rs 396 crore).

The T20 World Cup has already seen robust revenues and in time, will

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